

Orbit Financial Planning Architecture Decision Compendium

Meridian Group | Orbit Financial Planning | Synthetic enterprise project artifact

Executive Context

Orbit Financial Planning is a finance transformation initiative at Meridian Group. The goal is to replace fragmented planning spreadsheets with rolling forecast and scenario planning. The program is designed as an operating-model change, not just a technical implementation.

The project team includes FP&A, Finance Leadership, Business Unit Owners, Data Platform, Internal Audit. Decision records, meeting transcripts and working documents intentionally overlap so a long-term memory system can preserve both current truth and historical rationale.

Business Requirements

The solution must improve consistency, traceability and decision quality without creating hidden systems of record. Key first-phase principles are: ERP actuals remain authoritative; AI cannot change forecast values; Scenario phase 1 is limited to finance leadership.

Users need understandable status, accountable ownership, explicit exception paths, and enough provenance to explain why a decision or result exists. Material changes must be reflected in acceptance criteria and operating documentation.

Architecture and Dependencies

The solution is composed of ERP, Planning Inputs, Finance Ingestion, Forecast Engine, Scenario Store, Planning Workspace. Component boundaries exist so source-system authority, project-owned processing and downstream user experiences remain explicit.

Cross-project dependencies include PULSE: shared platform compute and batch windows. Shared dependency timing is managed through enterprise architecture and project steering rather than by silently duplicating shared capabilities.

Delivery and Risk

Primary risks include template incompatibility, platform capacity contention, ERP close delay, scenario scope expansion, manual adjustment governance. These risks are treated as business and operating-model concerns in addition to technical concerns because each can change adoption, support effort or the reliability of business decisions.

A dependency delay does not automatically move the project milestone. The project manager first evaluates resequencing, degraded-mode operation, scope protection and temporary controls before seeking a formal decision.

Governance and Traceability

Material decisions retain rationale, alternatives, owner and supersession history. Older assumptions are preserved because they explain why the project evolved. Current truth should be determined from accepted decision status and provenance, not simply the newest timestamp.

Temporary exceptions require an owner and review condition. Shared SMEs resolve enterprise-standard questions; local teams may not redefine shared semantics purely to unblock a milestone.

Decision Summaries

1. Forecast cadence: Monthly rolling forecast replaces quarterly-only planning. Rationale: Finance leadership needs earlier visibility into changing business conditions and assumptions. 2. Actuals: ERP actuals remain authoritative; manual spreadsheet adjustments are exceptions. Rationale: A single authoritative actuals source reduces reconciliation and audit ambiguity. 3. Platform: Orbit uses the shared analytical platform with Pulse. Rationale: Shared ingestion and analytical services reduce duplicate data engineering and governance overhead. 4. AI scope: AI may draft variance narratives but cannot change forecasts. Rationale: Narrative assistance is reversible and reviewable; forecast values remain accountable human decisions. 5. Scenario planning: Scenario planning is phase 1 for finance leadership, phase 2 for business units. Rationale: A smaller initial audience reduces template proliferation while the governance model is proven.

Rejected Patterns

Avoid project-local master data, undocumented exception handling, hidden permission bypasses, premature expansion of scope and deleting superseded decisions. These patterns reduce traceability and transfer cost to support teams.